

Geckos and snake-lizards

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Reptilia
ORDER	Squamata
SUBORDER	Lacertilia
SUPERFAMILY	Gekkota
FAMILIES	7
SPECIES	1,700

Geckos are small, vocal, usually nocturnal lizards. Some are agile climbers, capable of finding purchase on smooth, vertical, or even overhanging surfaces, including tree trunks, rock faces, and walls and ceilings. There are also many desert species, most of which live in burrows or rock crevices, emerging at night to forage on the ground. Geckos are cosmopolitan lizards, found in most tropical and subtropical countries and on many oceanic islands. This group also includes 2 types of legless lizards that are found only in Australasia. Snake-lizards, which have scaly flaps in place of legs, live on the ground, while blind lizards have eyes that are covered with scales, and live in underground burrows.

a communal egg-laying site, which can contain several dozen incubating eggs as well as the remnants of hatched ones. A few species give birth to pairs of live young. Many demonstrate temperature-dependent sex determination: males are born at higher temperatures, above 88° F (31° C), and females at lower ones.

Anatomy

Most geckos are small, slender lizards with a relatively large, flat head and large eyes with vertical pupils. Day geckos are often brightly colored, whereas the more typical nocturnal geckos are dull gray or brown to help them blend in with their surroundings. Some also have extraordinary shapes with, for example, leaflike tails to help them with camouflage.

Climbing geckos often have long claws and sometimes flattened pads at the end of each toe. These toe pads, usually absent in ground-dwelling species, are made of thousands of microscopic structures that provide adhesion, allowing them to climb

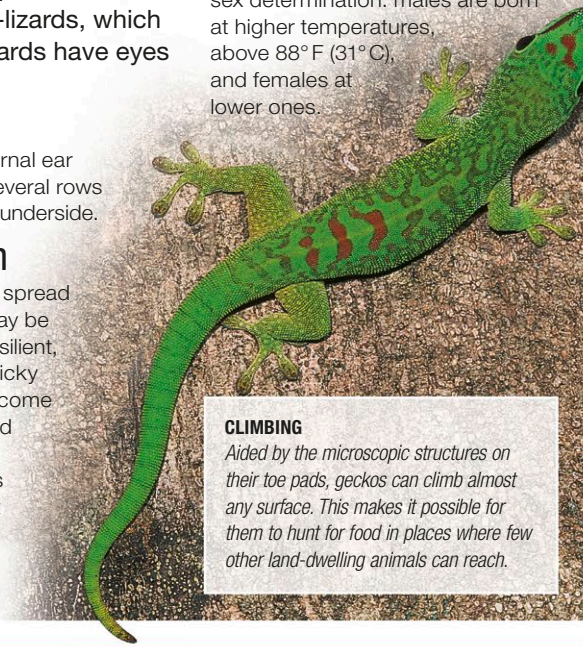
vertical surfaces or even to hang upside down. Some geckos (from the family Gekkonidae) do not have functional eyelids; instead, their eyes are covered with a transparent scale, as in snakes, which they keep clean with their tongue. Others (from the family Eublepharidae) do have eyelids and can blink—they are mostly ground dwellers from deserts, but some live in caves and one is arboreal. Geckos are unique among lizards in producing an array of sounds that are used to attract mates or to defend territory.

Snake lizards are long and slender, and may have pointed snouts. Like some geckos, they lack functional eyelids, but can be distinguished from

snakes by their external ear openings and the several rows of scales along their underside.

Reproduction

Geckos' successful spread around the world may be partly due to their resilient, hard-shelled, and sticky eggs, which can become attached to uprooted trees and drifting debris. Most species lay eggs in pairs but some small geckos lay a single egg at a time. Several females may use



CLIMBING
Aided by the microscopic structures on their toe pads, geckos can climb almost any surface. This makes it possible for them to hunt for food in places where few other land-dwelling animals can reach.

Coleonyx variegatus

Western banded gecko



Length 4¾–6 in (12–15 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.W. USA, N.W. Mexico



Unlike typical geckos, the western banded gecko has prominent eyes with movable lids. It appears delicate and

translucent, its tiny scales giving a silky texture to its skin. A secretive, nocturnal lizard, it hides during the day in rock crevices, and actively forages at night for small insects and spiders. When captured, it squeaks and may discard its tail. Other defense tactics involve raising its body and curling its tail over its back to look bigger and, possibly, to mimic a scorpion. Females lay 2 soft-shelled eggs at a time.



Eublepharis macularius

Common leopard gecko



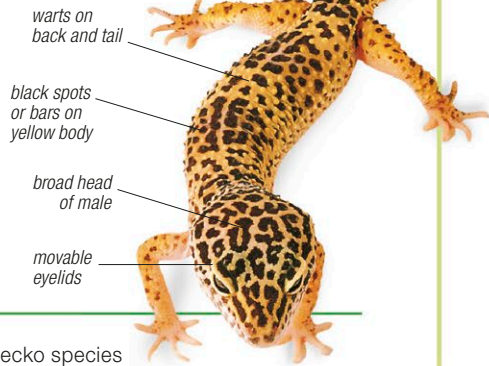
Length 8–10 in (20–25 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Not evaluated

Location S. Asia



The common leopard gecko has a thick tail that is used to store food. In times of plenty, the tail increases in size, but it shrinks during droughts, when the surplus food is metabolized. It may be

discarded in defense, but not as readily as in some other lizards. This gecko forages at night. It shelters from extreme heat and cold in burrows or under rocks, hibernates in winter, and may estivate in summer. It has been known to live up to 25 years in captivity.



Hemitheconyx caudicinctus

African fat-tailed gecko



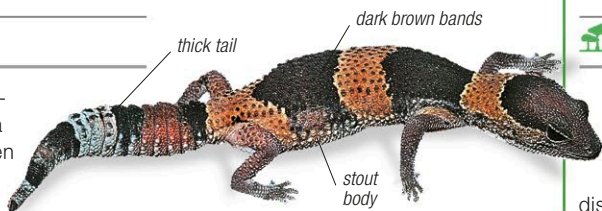
Length 6 in (15 cm), max 10 in (25 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location W. Africa



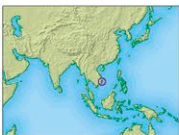
The tail of the African fat-tailed gecko is used as a food-storage organ; when the lizard is well fed, its tail becomes thicker.

It has a tan body with dark brown bands across the back and a broad, dark brown head. Males have a bulge at the base of the tail. A shy animal with a lifespan of about 25 years, it lives in dry savanna, rocky hillsides, or river banks, retreating during the day into burrows and actively foraging for insects at night. It estivates in the dry season. This gecko sometimes bites or discards its tail in defense.



Cyrtodactylus hontreensis

Hon Tre bent-toed gecko



Length 5 in (13 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Cave-climbing
Status Not evaluated

Location Vietnam



Known only from the cave system of Kien Giang Biosphere Reserve on Vietnam's Hon Tre Island, this distinctively patterned gecko was discovered in 2006. It is one of 5 new

gecko species endemic to the island and the second that belongs to the genus *Cyrtodactylus*. However, scientists believe there are many more species of geckos that have yet to be discovered. The Hon Tre bent-toed lizard is pale pink in color, with 5 or so darker, broad, white-edged bands that transverse the length of its slender body from its neck to the base of its tail. It also has 14 irregularly arranged, longitudinal rows of low, smooth tubercles running along the middle region of its body. It belongs to a large genus of "bow-fingered" geckos with delicate birdlike feet armed with claws—enabling it to grip the rocky surfaces of its habitat. Its habits are, so far, little known.